If you think history is repeating itself, you're right. In my second book, I talked about the stereo system I just had to have when I was 17—the one I blew $1,700 on for a down payment before making the stupid decision to put the remaining $1,800 on credit. That number seemed totally manageable when I had a job, less so after I was laid off. I would have been paying that $1,800 off at 16 percent interest, compounded monthly, for *years* if my brother Shane hadn't bailed me out. Now, 40 years later, here was my son wanting me to finance his own fancy electronic equipment. I suddenly understood my stepfather, George, in a way I never had before.

Trevor, being only 15, didn't have a credit card, but he did have a savings account. For the previous two summers, he had worked cleaning boats—a demanding job in the hot sun, but ultimately worth it at $11 an hour. He had saved close to $1,000. The way it works in our house is like this: if you want to drive, you're responsible for all the associated fees—driver's education courses, procuring a license, and—if you're hell-bent on having your own wheels—buying a car. My kids also have to pay for their own insurance. So Trevor had saved this thousand dollars thinking about getting his license. But now he was faced with a conundrum: buying the tracker system would completely decimate his account and he wouldn't be able to start driving lessons.

"C'mon, Dad," he begged. "Just a little loan?"

You might think I'm heartless, but I practice what I preach. The money lessons we'd spent the last 15 years drilling into our son's head were finally being called to account. If I backed down now and became the fairy godfather, Trevor would have learned that it was all just a game and that I'd bail him out of any future money problems he'd come to have. And there was no way I wanted a son of mine to think that.